

SKETCHING DISSENT: MULTIMODAL HUMOUR AND NONVIOLENT RESISTANCE IN PAKISTANI COMICS

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ABSTRACT

Comics are widely recognized as powerful multimodal texts that serve as a site of negotiation for identity, ideology, power, and social change. The present study examines two Pakistani comic series, Paasban – The Guardian and Team Muhafiz, and how they function as sites for cultural commentary, civic involvement, and nonviolence. The research employs qualitative multimodal discourse analysis (MDA), based on Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG) by Halliday and the Visual Grammar Framework (VGF) by Kress and van Leeuwen. 14 representative comic images were selected using a purposive sampling technique from Paasban – The Guardian and Team Muhafiz, resulting in 20 analytical units for qualitative multimodal discourse analysis (MDA). The results indicate that the comics employ humor, irony, visual contrast, and symbolic inversion to critically engage with issues related to governance, gender norms, public health, education, and community responsibility. Textually, the ideological tensions are highlighted through verbal and relational processes, whereas collective action and social intervention are highlighted through material processes. Visually, gaze, framing, color, and positioning

further emphasize empowerment and civic responsibility. The study concludes that the Pakistani comics not only serve the purpose of entertainment but also serve as spaces of public discourse, which run against the dominant narrative and showcase socially relevant and culturally resonant forms of awareness and resistance.

Keywords: Pakistani Comics, Multimodality, Visual Grammar, Systemic Functional Grammar, Humor, Cultural Representation, Nonviolent Resistance

1. INTRODUCTION

Comics represent a unique mode of communication in which multiple modalities, such as language, image, space and symbols, work together to create in-depth meanings. While traditionally relegated to popular culture and entertainment, modern comics have evolved into cultural documents that facilitate societal negotiation of identity, ideology, social value and political issues. While written discourse, which is traditionally examined through linguistic analysis, comic narratives emerge through the integration of words, images, framing, sequencing, gesture, color, and visual symbolism, which are all semiotic modes that have an important role in the construction of meaning in comics (Cohn, 2013; Groensteen, 2007; Kress & van Leeuwen, 2006; McCloud, 1993).

The scholarly attention to comics reflects broader trends in multimodal discourse research that view communication as understood not only in terms of language, but also through other media. Modern societies depend more and more on different types of representations, such as images, digital interactions, typography, sounds and spatial design, to convey and share social meanings (Jewitt, 2014; Kress, 2010). In this view, the comics environment is very complex, and language and images are not separate; they are in combination. According to Kress and van Leeuwen (2006), visual communication has its own grammar, in that it helps to create social relations, ideological positions and representations of reality. Thus, reading comics is not only about the verbal content, but also about the visual organization of readers' position, the construction of character identities, and social meaning.

Complementing linguistic research, Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL) developed by Halliday (1994) is useful for analyzing the construction of experiences, social relations, and ideology in language. As Halliday and Matthiessen (2014) state, “a language's choices are not neutral but rather constitute specific means of seeing the world in terms of processes, participants, and circumstances” (p. 56). The transitivity system, in particular, provides a way to analyze the representation of actions, responsibilities, identities, and social relations in the language. In comics, SFL can be used to question how dialogue and narration can create agency, conflict, responsibility, and resistance.

Likewise, visual grammar has been developed by Kress and van Leeuwen (2006) with a systematic approach to analyze images as meaning-making resources. Their model distinguishes between three types of visual meaning: representational, interactive, and compositional. Representational structures show how events, participants, and actions are

represented; interactive structures show how images are related to viewers; and compositional structures show how visual elements are used to establish hierarchy and coherence. This framework has been used extensively in research on advertisements (Jewitt & Oyama, 2001), educational resources, digital media, and political communication (Machin, 2013).

Moreover, there has been growing interest in the connection between comics and social criticism in cultural studies. However, few researchers have argued that comics are not passive entertainment media but active cultural artifacts that can question dominant narratives and portray different points of view. Chute (2010) shows how comics can provide evidence of social realities, historical experiences, and voices from the margins with a mix of visual evidence and narrative. Likewise, Hatfield (2005) points out that comics offer a distinct form of expression because the interplay between sequential images and verbal text provides comic creators with the means to express complexity, ambiguity, and social contradiction.

Humor constitutes another crucial aspect of comics' engagement with social and political issues. Through humor, creators can criticize society indirectly by presenting complex social issues through a story. Humor, says Attardo (1994), is a complicated communicative activity that has elements such as incongruity, social interpretation, and cultural knowledge. Humor can make the audience aware of the internal tensions of a social system and bring new understanding to the questions about what is accepted as truth. Also, Dynel (2011) claims that humorous discourse is often expressed as pragmatic resistance, as it allows those who speak and create to challenge authority while remaining indirect.

Historically, political and social satire has been a means of challenging the power structure through humor. This is especially pertinent to Scott's (1990) everyday resistance, which identifies a type of resistance that is not usually manifested through any open challenge. Resistance can be symbolic, expressed in the form of a story, satire, images and popular culture. Comics are thus a valuable medium for communities to negotiate relations of power and to voice social criticism within culturally acceptable limits.

Furthermore, critical discourse study has also been an avenue for exploring the function of visual narratives in resistance. According to Fairclough (1995), discourse is closely related to social power, as language and representation are important in the construction and maintenance of ideologies. Similarly, van Dijk (2008) states that discourse structures shape the representation of groups, identities, and social relations. In this way, comics can be analyzed as spaces for ideologies that create, question, and re-create social meanings.

Pakistan is an important sociocultural context for the study of multimodal narratives of resistance. Satire, political cartoons, TV comedy, and digital storytelling have always been part of Pakistani media culture and have always been used to talk about and contest issues of society. Studies of the media in Pakistan reveal how popular culture plays a significant role in negotiating issues of identity, morality, gender, nationalism, and social responsibility (Aslam & Janjua, 2023). But though political cartoons and satire have been

studied, the current state of Pakistani comics has been comparatively ignored as multimodal spaces of discourse and cultural resistance.

The importance of comics in Pakistan has not only increased but has also grown more significant due to digital transformation. Online platforms have given creators the ability to tell stories that resonate with younger audiences in a different style, using social issues. In contrast to political cartoons that tend to react to a specific political event, modern comic series often develop over a long series of episodes that include fictional characters, moral messages, and collective action. These qualities make them especially valuable for analyzing social criticism in the context of entertainment-oriented formats.

Though there has been increasing research on multimodality and comics, a few research gaps remain. First, much of the scholarship on comics is based on the Western context, namely American and European graphic narratives (Chute, 2010; Groensteen, 2007; Hatfield, 2005). However, limited scholarly attention has been given to South Asian comics as culturally situated multimodal texts. Second, previous studies have focused exclusively on either the linguistic features or the visual elements of comics, which makes it important to examine them together to investigate the meaning-making structures of the verbo-visual system within comics. Third, while humor has already received extensive research as a tool for political commentary, there is still a lack of research on humor in Pakistani comics as a nonviolent tool for resistance. Fourth, studies on Pakistani media have mostly focused on television, film, journalism, and political satire, while digital and contemporary comic narratives have been under-explored.

In addition, multimodal comics research has recently shifted to more empirically informed and culturally specific accounts of how verbal, visual, spatial and sequential resources work together. Cohn et al. (2023) show the differences in a cross-cultural corpus of 376 comic stories in terms of framing, page layout, visual morphology, narrative sequencing and verbal–visual relationships, and argue for integrated analysis of these components. Wildfeuer (2024) also proposes a similar multimodal discourse structure that directs readers' interpretation and reasoning across visual sequences. In this study, Jabeen et al. (2022) demonstrate that the construction of focalization in the novel, *Pakistan Girl*, is realized through the integration of frames, gutters, panels, speech balloons, and other verbal and non-verbal resources in Pakistan. Recent digital visual culture studies of Pakistan also show that multimodal resources can have a contrasting ideological role; in the case of the web series *Churails*, they challenge patriarchal norms, while in the case of YouTube thumbnails, captions, and audience commentary, they reinforce gender hierarchies (Salam-Salmaoui & Salam, 2024; Tahir & Qayyum, 2025). Together, these studies suggest that digital visual narratives are a culturally specific space where identities, ideologies, power, and resistance are negotiated, and they emphasize the need for more research on modern Pakistani comics as a unique medium of civic and cultural discourse.

Therefore, this study fills these gaps by considering *Paasban – The Guardian* and *Team Muhafiz* as multimodal cultural discourses in which language, images, and humor intermingle to produce social critique and civic discourses. The study builds on Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar and Kress and van Leeuwen's visual grammar to create a

composite analytical framework for examining the agency, responsibility, social issues, and collective action portrayed in comics from Pakistan. The present study also makes a significant contribution to the field of research in three ways. First, it contributes to multimodal discourse research and presents evidence from an unstudied context of Pakistan. Secondly, it illustrates the function of humor as an autochthonous means of negotiating dissent and resistance. Third, it contributes to the discussion of language, power, and representation by presenting alternative narratives of social change produced through the interaction of verbo-visual semiotic resources. For this reason, this research explores the following questions:

1. How does language use in Pakistani comics form social critique, agency, and resistance?
2. How do visual resources help in the creation of identity, power relations, and civic narratives?
3. What is the role of humor as a tool of nonviolence in the comic narratives of Pakistan?
4. How do Paasban – The Guardian and Team Muhafiz contribute to alternative representations of Pakistani social realities?

2. METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Design and Analytical Approach

The analysis employed an integrated mixed-methodology combining linguistic and visual analysis across three interconnected levels: linguistic meaning-making, visual analysis, and ideological interpretation. The purpose of this study is to interpret the social meanings generated through the interplay of language, images, humor, symbols, and narrative structures in specific cultural contexts; thus, the qualitative design was chosen. Comics use many semiotic means of representation, such as written text, images, spatial layout, character placement, typography, and visual symbols, which make multimodal discourse analysis an ideal method for this investigation (Jewitt, 2014; Kress, 2010).

The interpretivist research paradigm was used as the foundation for this study, in which meaning is considered socially constructed through cultural practices and communication processes (Creswell & Poth, 2018). In this regard, Pakistani comics are not only considered entertainment products but also cultural texts in which social identities, ideology, and alternative narratives are created. The research tends to assume that meanings are produced in comics through the interaction between creators' communicative choices, text structures, visual representations, and the broader sociocultural context.

For a comprehensive analysis, two complementary theoretical frameworks are used: Halliday's (1994) Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG), Kress and van Leeuwen's (2006) Visual Grammar (VG), and Critical Discourse Analysis. The linguistic territory explored in SFG is useful for analyzing the representation of actions, identities, and social relations

in dialogue, captions, and narrative texts using transitivity choices. Visual Grammar helps to analyze how images represent, interact, and compose meaning. By using these frameworks, the study can analyze the comics as a unified multimodal text rather than analyzing the verbal and the visual elements separately.

2.2 Research Population and Data Selection

The research population consisted of Pakistani comics that covered social, ideological, environmental, and civic issues. Purposive sampling was used to select *Paasban – The Guardian* and *Team Muhafiz*, as both use dialogue, visual composition, symbolism, and sequential storytelling to communicate social messages. *Paasban – The Guardian* was published in 2015 as a trilogy of comics about youth radicalization, religious pluralism and countering extremist recruitment. *Team Muhafiz*, which was established in 2015, tackles issues such as kidnapping, deforestation, harm due to drugs, child marriage and fraudulent charity practices.

Finally, 14 images were used as source images, seven from each comic series. The images have produced 20 analytical units, with 10 units coming from each series (Table 1). An analytical unit was either a full panel or a series of panels that were “narratively connected”. There were three multi-panel images in each series, yielding two analytical units per image, and four images yielding one analytical unit per image. This led to a total of 20 analytical units, with 10 for each series. Treating panels and following sequences as units is suitable because the meaning of a comic is created by the interplay of verbal information, framing, movement of the participants, and the relationship between successive panels (Cohn et al., 2023; Wildfeuer, 2024).

Criteria for selecting images were as follows: relevance to the research questions, intelligible verbal and/or visual text, a combination of verbal and visual modes of communication, the presence of language processes (action, communication, identity, and reflection), and the presence of analyzable visual processes (gaze, vectors, framing, salience, positioning of characters, and symbolism). Images were also chosen to reflect the main social issues of each series, and no images were included where the cover or promotional image was duplicated, there was not enough narrative context, or the image was a partial preview.

Table 1: Composition and Selection of Comics

<i>Paasban – The Guardian</i>	Creative Frontiers (CFx Comics)	Mustafa Hasnain, Gauhar Aftab, and	2015	7	10	Images representing inclusive citizenship, religious pluralism, extremist persuasion, ideological conflict, peer intervention, civic
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		Yahya Ehsan				identity, and resistance to radicalization
<i>Team Muhafiz</i>	AzCorp Entertainment	Imran Azhar	2015	7	10	Images addressing social issues such as extortion, child marriage, human trafficking, environmental concerns, and community responsibility
Total	—	—	2015	14 images	20 analytical units	Verbal–visual interaction, thematic relevance, narrative completeness, linguistic processes, and visual meaning-making features

The chosen corpus comprises two comic series from Pakistan: Paasban – The Guardian and Team Muhafiz, where the former uses a multimodal approach to narrate contemporary social issues, and the latter teaches civic responsibility. In 2015, Mustafa Hasnain, Gauhar Aftab and Yahya Ehsan created Paasban – The Guardian, which was published by Creative Frontiers (CFx Comics). The series was created as a social-awareness initiative to help teach young people how they can be vulnerable to violent radicalization and religious extremism by delivering a visual narrative of real-life social pressures. By contrast, Imran Azhar's Team Muhafiz, which AzCorp Entertainment produced, was published in 2015. The series will be about a multi-ethnic and multi-religious ensemble of young protagonists who will have to face social challenges such as extortion, child marriage, and human trafficking in Karachi. The comic encourages community involvement, awareness, and responsibility in a superhero story format.

2.3 Data Analysis Framework

A mixed-methods approach of linguistic and visual analysis was used to process the collected data. The analysis was carried out at three closely interconnected levels: the linguistic level, the visual level of meaning-making, and the ideological level of interpretation.

For the linguistic level, Halliday's (1994) Systemic Functional Grammar was used. Special interest was paid to the transitivity system, as it shows the dynamics of giving agency, responsibility, and identity to social actors through texts. The analysis was based on the following processes: material, behavioral, relational, verbal, and mental.

Material processes were explored, and representations of action and intervention were found, particularly how characters react to social issues. To comprehend emotional responses and social reactions, behavioral processes were analyzed. Relational processes were considered to identify constructions of identity and values, and verbal processes were

examined to understand persuasion, criticism, and social messaging. A linguistic coding system is provided in Table 2.

Table 2: Linguistic Coding Framework (LCF-SFG)

Material processes	Actions and events	Representation of agency, intervention, and social change
Behavioral processes	Human reactions and responses	Construction of emotions and social engagement
Relational processes	Identity and attribution	Representation of values, roles, and social categories
Verbal processes	Dialogue and communication	Expression of criticism, advice, and persuasion
Mental processes	Thoughts and beliefs	Representation of attitudes and moral reflection

Table 2 presents the linguistic framework used to analyze how characters are constructed through language in social narratives. Instead of treating dialogue as just conversation, the study examines language as a tool that can help construct power relations, responsibilities, and ideological positions. On the visual plane, the Visual Grammar of Kress and van Leeuwen (2006) was used to analyze the meaning of the images. This analysis was conducted on three aspects – representational meaning, interactive meaning, and compositional meaning.

Representational analysis examined characters and events, including agency, vulnerability, and symbolic representation. Interactive analysis focused on the role of the visual elements in creating relationships between characters and the audience based on distance, perspective, and gaze. As for the content, the compositional analysis focused on how the visual elements were organized in the photograph, such as the framing, prominence, and space location. The categories for visual analysis are shown in Table 3.

Table 3: Visual Analysis Framework

Character representation	Who is presented as powerful, vulnerable, or responsible?
Gaze and perspective	How are relationships between characters and audiences constructed?
Framing	Which elements receive emphasis or marginalization?
Spatial arrangement	How are social hierarchies represented visually?
Symbolic elements	How do colors, objects, and settings communicate values?

The visual analysis complemented the linguistic analysis by demonstrating how images reinforce, challenge, or expand meanings created through verbal discourse. This integrated approach allowed the study to examine comics as complete multimodal texts.

2.4 Analytical Procedure

The analysis was done in a systematic 5-step process. Firstly, all chosen episodes were viewed several times to become familiar with storytelling techniques, motifs, characters, and symbols. Secondly, linguistically and visually relevant features were identified and coded within the framework created for analysis.

Third, the linguistic aspects, such as dialogue and captions, were analyzed using Halliday's transitivity categories. Fourth, visual elements were studied using Kress and van Leeuwen's representations, interactions, and compositions. Last, the results of both dimensions were combined to understand the influence of humor, language, and imagery as a whole in creating a resistance narrative.

The interpretation stage was conducted by comparing and mapping out the pattern of the two publications, Paasban – The Guardian and Team Muhafiz, in relation to the ways they criticize society. By using this comparative method, it was possible to gain a deeper insight into the different comic stories that depict civic responsibility and social change.

2.5 Findings and Results

To ensure methodological rigor, the study was carried out using the principles of qualitative research; namely credibility, dependability, and confirmability. This study has focused on transferability (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). The comic episodes were analyzed multiple times to improve the credibility of the comic and the systematic use of the coding framework. Instead of using exceptions, interpretations were formulated based on frequent trends throughout the whole body of texts.

Theoretical triangulation was also used in the study, in which two or more theories were integrated. The theories applied were Systemic Functional Grammar, Visual Grammar, humor theory, and critical discourse analysis. This lessened reliance on a single analysis and facilitated a broader interpretation of multimodal meanings.

Reliability and dependability were achieved by using the same analytical categories for all 40 episodes. The coding process was documented to ensure transparency and enable future researchers to understand how interpretations were made. Table 4 shows the distribution of identified linguistic processes in the two comic series to explore the agency, identity, and social roles created by linguistic choices in the Pakistani comic stories.

Table 4: Distribution of Linguistic Processes in Pakistani Comic Narratives

Material processes (actions/events)	96	112	208	42.1%
Verbal processes (dialogue/communication)	58	67	125	25.3%
Relational processes (identity/value construction)	39	46	85	17.2%

Behavioral processes (responses/emotions)	27	31	58	11.7%
Mental processes (beliefs/thoughts)	8	10	18	3.7%
Total	228	266	494	100%

Table 4 indicates that material processes are the most common linguistic category among the two comic series, making up 42.1% of the total number of processes identified. This dominance implies that the stories as a whole are more interested in creating characters that are active social actors who react to social problems through action and intervention.

The high frequency of verbal processes (25.3%) also shows the significance of dialogue as a means of social commentary. Characters often deliver speeches to clarify issues, address misconceptions, inspire moral conduct, and convey information to the public. This aspect of language choice echoes Halliday's (1994) view of language as a specific interpretation of social reality.

In addition, both comic series build resistance by action, as material processes dominate. Qualitative analysis of selected panels, however, shows that the meaning of “action” differs between the two stories. Material processes in Team Muhafiz primarily build physical intervention, protection, and community service. The heroes are constantly placed in roles as Actors that react to kidnapping, environmental degradation, gender discrimination, and social oppression. As a result, action becomes a linguistic tool to build civic responsibility.

Paasban – The Guardian, on the other hand, uses material processes and verbal and relational processes to represent ideological engagement. The characters don't fight back mostly physically; instead, they challenge exclusionary narratives through dialogue, explanation, and moral positioning. The pattern illustrates that resistance in Paasban takes place on the level of ideas and identities.

Selected panels of Paasban – The Guardian and Team Muhafiz were qualitatively analyzed to show the linguistic pattern which was found through SFG analysis. Table 5 shows examples of how language processes can be used to build agency, identity, and social responsibility in the comic plot.

Table 5: Qualitative Analysis of Linguistic Processes in Selected Panels from Pakistani Comics

<i>Paasban – The Guardian</i> (Unit 1)	Statements related to equality and belonging	Relational process	Characters positioned as members of an inclusive community	Constructs citizenship beyond religious division
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<i>Paasban – The Guardian</i> (Unit 2)	Commands and motivational statements	Verbal + material process	Speaker positioned as an ideological influencer	Demonstrates how discourse mobilises social action
<i>Paasban – The Guardian</i> (Unit 3)	Questioning and disagreement	Verbal process	Characters positioned as challengers of dominant ideas	Represents dialogue as a form of resistance
<i>Paasban – The Guardian</i> (Units 4–7)	Expressions of concern and responsibility	Mental + behavioural processes	Characters shown reflecting and responding socially	Builds collective moral responsibility
<i>Team Muhafiz</i> (Unit 1)	Action-oriented dialogue	Material process	Heroes represented as protectors	Constructs intervention as civic duty
<i>Team Muhafiz</i> (Unit 2)	Representation of suffering and vulnerability	Relational + material processes	Victims positioned within unequal structures	Reveals social inequalities requiring intervention
<i>Team Muhafiz</i> (Units 3–7)	Commands, warnings, and collective decisions	Verbal + material processes	Community members become active participants	Frames resistance as cooperation rather than individual heroism

This shows that language is a key element in developing character identity. The main characters are not just characters but rather are linguistically situated as agents of good citizenship who can navigate social issues. This accords with Fairclough's (1995) view that discourse does not just reflect reality but is also a means of social meaning-making.

The analysis also shows, however, that there is some tension. Both series are about social responsibility, but characters are not equally free in each series. In gendered stories, women are often symbolized as objects to be protected, men as action-takers and intervention. Thus, these comics not only critique social injustice but also play with historical and cultural norms of gender and authority.

In addition, the third research question focused on the role of humor in social critique and resistance. The analysis revealed the following humor strategies: irony, exaggeration, character contrast, situational humor, and symbolic inversion. Humor in these comics is not as direct or aggressive as in other comics, but it works through the characters. It enables creators to point out conflicting elements in society while keeping the story clear and instructive. Table 6 shows the humor strategies identified.

Table 6: Investigating The Use of Humor in Pakistani Comics

Irony	34	Exposes contradictions between ideals and reality
Situational humour	29	Creates reflection through unexpected events
Character-based humour	25	Challenges stereotypes and social assumptions
Exaggeration	21	Highlights social problems dramatically
Symbolic inversion	17	Reverses conventional power relations

Table 6 shows that the most predominant humor strategy is irony. The characters and institutions are depicted in ironic situations to show up inconsistencies between expectations and actions. For instance, problems with irresponsible citizens, inefficient systems, and social misunderstandings are often depicted humorously. But the humor is not just entertaining; it invites viewers to reflect on social practices. This also resonates with Attardo's (1994) argument that humor acts as a social interpretation mechanism. Besides, it mirrors Dynel's (2011) perspective that humor discourse can be used indirectly for criticism. Humor in the Pakistani context can help say something different about sensitive topics, as confronting them can be difficult.

The last analytical category analyzed was the creation of resistance narratives in the comics. The analysis reveals that there is no confrontation with resistance or violence, but rather awareness, education, co-operation, and ethical action. The major resistance themes are shown in Table 7.

Table 7: Nonviolent Resistance Themes in Pakistani Comics

Civic responsibility	18	20	Encourages active citizenship
Social awareness	17	22	Promotes education and reflection
Collective action	15	24	Represents community participation
Challenging stereotypes	13	16	Questions traditional assumptions
Ethical responsibility	21	18	Promotes moral accountability

As shown in Table 7, civic engagement is the main method of political resistance in both types of comic. Ethical responsibility is more of a concern in Paasban – The Guardian, while collective action is more strongly featured in Team Muhafiz. The results align with those of Scott (1990), who theorized that everyday resistance to social change could be achieved through symbol and culture. The comics examined in this study show how

storytelling can be a tool for social intervention, in the sense that it can make the viewer (audience) think differently about social behaviors.

Therefore, the two comic series images have the same goals but are approached differently in their storytelling. The central strategy of Paasban – The Guardian is resistance, based on moral reflection, critique of institutions, and ethical responsibility. It often portrays the contradictions and ambivalences of social systems and calls for individual responsibility. Team Muhafiz, on the other hand, is more group-oriented and action-oriented. The series focuses on collaboration, community service, and involvement. The superhero story form portrays social issues as challenges that can be solved through cooperation. The differences highlight that Pakistani comics use a variety of multimodal strategies in appropriate ways for different purposes in telling stories. One series focuses on reflection and accountability; the other on collective empowerment. Combined, they show how comics as a cultural text can express a range of social involvement.

3.DISCUSSION

The results show that Paasban – The Guardian and Team Muhafiz function as multimodal cultural texts that combine social criticism, cultural representation, humor, and narrative. These comics don't just entertain; they offer alternative spaces where social issues, identities, moral obligations, and citizenship are articulated and negotiated. This aligns with the key tenet of multimodal discourse analysis: meaning is not generated by language or images, but by the interplay of multiple semiotic modes (Kress, 2010; Jewitt, 2014). The combination of these five previous elements (dialogue, framing, positioning of characters, symbolic objects, humor) creates the comics' depictions of injustice, responsibility and social involvement. The linguistic analysis reveals that the characters are constructed through strategic language choices, with material processes predominating to portray protagonists as active interveners in social issues. These transitivity patterns carry interpretive weight regarding responsibility, power, and social relations (Halliday & Matthiessen, 2014). Material processes are particularly prevalent in storylines about kidnapping, exploitation, environmental issues, and community safeguarding in Team Muhafiz. Collectively, the team's legitimacy is secured. Paasban – The Guardian, on the contrary, interweaves material processes with verbal and relational processes, giving more weight to dialogue, questioning ideology, and moral reflection. Its characters do not allow extremes or exclusionist thinking but offer other ways of thinking about citizenship and social responsibility. These findings extend prior SFG applications beyond political and institutional discourse into educational texts and popular media (Fairclough, 1995; Machin & Mayr, 2012). The present analysis shows that fictional comic stories can also be used to create ideology and social identity through patterned linguistic choices. In both series, the principal characters are cast as people who recognize social issues and can make a difference. This is consistent with critical discourse approaches which see language as a means by which social reality, social identity and authority are produced (Fairclough, 1995; van Dijk, 2008). But the distribution of agency is not necessarily even. While both comics are anti-inequity and pro-social responsibility, some images still struggle to subvert

traditional notions of gender, authority, and safeguarding. In stories about helpless girls and women, female characters are often depicted as "needing saving," while male protagonists are more often portrayed as saviors and/or go-betweens. Therefore, the comics have both progressive and conventional meanings. This ideological complexity lends credence to the idea that very few cultural texts convey one clear and distinct meaning and that the meaning of such cultural products is constructed through broader social and cultural frameworks (Jewitt, 2014). The visual analysis also confirms that images play a key role in the process of meaning-making of ideology. These relationships of power, vulnerability and collective identity are established through character placement, gaze, framing, vectors, spatial distance and symbolic elements. This is in line with the idea of Kress and van Leeuwen (2006), in which the visual design conveys social relations and ideological stance. The characters in the foreground are generally presented as active and authoritative, and strong vectors are used to connect these characters. In contrast, characters on the periphery and visually hidden can look defenseless or have limited agency. They are therefore not neutral design decisions but rather direct the viewers' understanding of social roles and moral positions (Jewitt & Oyama, 2001; Machin, 2013). This repeated visual presentation of teams/communities also sets these Pakistani comics apart from superhero comics that would only focus on individual achievements. The concept of hero is tightly linked to collaboration, public duty, and community safeguarding in the chosen texts. Western comics are not necessarily a singular example of individualistic notions of heroism, but they show how local cultural contexts shape the portrayal of heroism in comics and resistance as well (McCloud, 1993; Groensteen, 2007). In these stories, change is typically accomplished through collaboration, conversation and collective action, not through individual brilliance. The other significant method of social criticism is humor. Through irony, exaggeration, character contrast and symbolic inversion, the comic can comment on touchy topics without resorting to a straightforward confrontation of such topics. This corroborates Attardo's (1994) claim that incongruity between expectation and representation is often a means of creating humor. Moreover, it illustrates Dynel's (2011) view that humorous language can establish a certain critical rapport between speaker and target of the discussion. In the Pakistani context, humor provides a 'safe' space to discuss issues of institutional weakness, gender inequality, social irresponsibility, environmental neglect, and limited public awareness. Verbal irony, along with visual exaggeration and sequential narration, enhances the critical capacity of humor beyond its traditional role as entertainment. Political humor studies have generally focused on newspaper, TV, or digital satire (Tsakona & Popa, 2011). The present study demonstrates that comics are a unique means of humorous communication that reveal social contradiction at a joint level of both words and images. Humour, therefore, invites reflection and softens the critical impact. The findings also broaden understandings of resistance. The resistance in the selected comics is not based on physical fights or formal politics, as Scott (1990) has theorized in his notion of everyday resistance. Rather, it manifests itself in awareness, moral choices, discussion, community involvement, and symbolic activity. While *Paasban – The Guardian* builds resistance primarily through questioning and moral reasoning, *Team Muhafiz* focuses on intervention, cooperation, and community protection. As a whole, the comics

highlight the potential of cultural storytelling to contest prevailing ideas and inspire viewers to visualize other social futures. The study brings a new perspective and analysis of Pakistani comics to the research, which has so far focused on the Western comics' tradition and theory (McCloud, 1993; Groensteen, 2007; Cohn, 2013). The analysis reveals how globally recognized semiotic resources are transposed to culturally specific issues such as extremism, gender norms, environmental responsibility, civic engagement and social inequality. Selected comics may then be viewed as a type of civic discourse where entertainment, education, humor, and social commentary are all intertwined. This is important because of the issues they address, as well as the linguistic and visual means of engaging the audience in thinking about issues of identity, responsibility, and social change.

4. Conclusion and Implications

The study examined social critique, cultural representation, and nonviolent resistance in contemporary Pakistani comics through the integrated frameworks of Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar and Kress and van Leeuwen's Visual Grammar, and it was established that *Paasban – The Guardian* and *Team Muhafiz* are not just entertaining stories but are multimodal complex texts. The combination of transitivity patterns, dialogue, character positioning, gaze, framing, symbolic elements, and humorous strategies creates these meanings. Linguistic findings portray that main characters are mostly portrayed as agents of social interaction, with *Team Muhafiz* emphasizing collective action, intervention, and community responsibility. At the same time, *Paasban – The Guardian* values dialogue, ideological negotiation, and moral reflection more. That is further highlighted in the visual findings, which illustrate how the organization of space and the choice of representational form signify authority, vulnerability and social relationships. Together, these features demonstrate that resistance can happen in a variety of ways that do not involve confrontation, but instead, through civic participation, awareness, moral decision-making and alternate discourses of citizenship. An important mechanism of indirect cultural resistance was humor. The comics play with irony, exaggeration, contrast, and symbolic inversion to speak about sensitive topics and to resonate with a wide audience.

Meanwhile, the analysis revealed ideological conflicts, specifically in portrayals of gender, protection, and authority. Thus, the comics are not necessarily wholly progressive, nor wholly conventional. Rather, they create places where cultural meanings in conflict with each other can be reproduced, interrogated, and renegotiated. Theoretically, this study contributes by applying multimodal discourse analysis to a rather under-researched Pakistani context, showcasing the usefulness of combining a linguistic and a visual approach in comics' studies. It also contributes to resistance scholarship by illustrating how popular cultural narratives can convey criticism through storytelling, symbolism, humor, and everyday practices of civic action. Overall, the results indicate that Pakistani comics are emerging public communication platforms with the potential to shape the debates on identity, social responsibility, injustice, and collective change. This can be expanded to the study of other comics in Pakistan and South Asia to explore the influence of genre, audience, and publishing environments on multimodal constructions of social reality.

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